ON ANNOTATION

Name: _____ Date: _____ Class: _____

WHY READ?

Research estimates that at least **80% of college-level tasks** involve reading. But why do we read?

Reading is a social activity: the exchange of information between two or more conscious, intelligent beings.

Do you consider yourself a good communicator, an engaging storyteller, a decent conversationalist? (If not, do you prefer to work thoughts out on the page?)

Think about what makes for a worthwhile conversation. How do you know the person you're talking to is actually listening?

Through their reactions, both verbal and nonverbal! They reply with relevant comments or questions. They make eye contact. They nod or smile or emote as circumstance dictates. They engage with you in dialogue.

If you're talking to someone and they stare back, vacant, neither responding to what you're saying nor moving the conversation in another direction, it's unnerving. It's antisocial, anti-intellectual, maybe even anti-human. Most of us find monologuing in front of an icy audience somewhat unpleasant. We crave connection when we speak.

Have you ever spoken with somebody who doesn't seem to retain anything you're saying—someone who doesn't seem to be listening, but is definitely waiting for you to stop talking?

Doesn't feel good, does it? Feels like what you have to say is mere noise. Feels like you're an ordeal to be endured, not a human being with something urgent to share.

The same principle applies to reading. **Annotation is a dialogue between you and a text.** Reading is a social activity.

WHY WRITE?

Annotation allows you to identify key ideas in real-time, improving recall and retention.

Annotation provides you with an opportunity to append your running commentary to a text, creating a snapshot of your own reaction.

Annotation encourages you to ask and answer your own questions as you read, prioritizing your own understanding.

Annotation is a temporal investment. Yes, you'll spend more time with the text up front, but this time will return to you, bearing dividends, when you needn't hustle to locate the most important components of that text a second, third, fourth, fifth time.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN...

I don't want to prescribe a specific approach to annotation. The key is finding a system that works for you. That said, there are a few universal guidelines and a toolbox full of reliable strategies for you to rifle through.

Let's start with some pointers.

First, favor physical texts over digital versions whenever possible. If you prefer using markup tools on a computer, fair enough, but there's value in printing an article out or writing up notes on a separate sheet as you read.

Second, whenever you take up a text, start with a purpose. Ask yourself: why am I reading this? What do I hope to get out of it? What goal do I want to meet by the time I put this down?

Third, always finish reading before you annotate. Don't read with your pen in hand. Give yourself a little time to process information before you interact with it. Work at the level of the paragraph (in a dense text) or the page (if it's a bit breezier) as you annotate.

MAKE YOUR MARK!

When you annotate, you perform two basic tasks: you mark up the text and you write original notes. These exist in balance, but your notes should receive the majority of your time and attention.

Let's start with markup tools, which help draw attention to key parts of the text. Common approaches include highlighting, underlining, bracketing, drawing boxes, adding arrows, and placing symbols—like asterisks, daggers, exclamation points, and question marks—directly in the text.

Markup tools typically target key words and phrases, important passages, unfamiliar vocabulary, and any other material that catches your attention. They also seek out supporting details: facts, figures, statistics, quotes, paraphrases, summaries, and anecdotal evidence. Markups make spotting these features easier the next time you're looking for them.

You don’t need to use all of these tools. Don’t get in your own way! Pick a few that work and stick with them. Likewise, strive to avoid overusing the tools you do rely on.

Mark up text after you’ve finished reading it. When highlighting or underlining, limit yourself to just one phrase or sentence per paragraph. Unless you’re identifying a thesis, favor words and phrases over whole sentences.

Color-code your markings: for instance, you may highlight new vocabulary in blue and key words in yellow. You might use exclamation points to identify surprising evidence and question marks to indicate skepticism toward an author’s claim. Again, what matters is developing a system that works for you.

MAKE YOURSELF HEARD!

Wherever possible, interrupt a text with your own voice. Place your thoughts and observations directly on the page. If you can’t write on the page, use a notebook, loose-leaf paper, or sticky notes.

Notes can do more heavy lifting than other markup tools. Your notes can: paraphrase key info, reinforce important insights, ask and answer questions, connect what you're reading to prior knowledge, predict or extend an author's argument, make personal connections to the text, and summarize dense materials. Always include a summary at the end of important paragraphs, sections, or pages.

Take a goldilocks approach to notes while annotating: go beyond a few words or phrases, but avoid longwinded responses. The sweet spot is somewhere between a sentence fragment and a few sentences.

What should an annotation contain? It's glib, but an honest answer is whatever information you think you might want later.

Get out there and give it a whirl! It might take some trial and error to create a system that works for you, but marginalia can't help but respect your boundaries!